

Study Note

PLANNING BUSINESS MESSAGES

BUS201: Business and Human Communication

Planning Business Messages

Topic 3 | Week 3

Instructor

Nadia Afroze Disha (NAR)

Lecturer

BRAC Business School

BRAC University

BBA Program

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Effective business messages are purposeful, audience-centered, and concise, ensuring clear and impactful communication. Being **purposeful** means that each message is crafted with a specific objective in mind, whether it's to inform, request, or persuade. This focus helps keep the content relevant and directs the reader's attention to essential information. **Audience-centered** communication takes into account the needs, expectations, and interests of the recipient, allowing the message to resonate more effectively. When messages are tailored to the audience, they are more engaging and demonstrate empathy, making the reader more receptive to the content. Finally, **conciseness** is critical in business communication, as it eliminates unnecessary words or details, allowing the reader to grasp the main points quickly. This quality is especially important in a fast-paced business environment, where time is a valuable resource. By combining purpose, audience consideration, and brevity, effective business messages deliver information in a way that is both impactful and respectful of the reader's time.

UNDERSTANDING THE THREE-STEP WRITING PROCESS

No matter what kind of information you need to convey, your goal is to craft a message that is **effective** (it meets your audience's needs and gets your points across) and **efficient** (it makes the best use of your time and your audience's time). Following a clear and proven three-step process (see Figure 3.1) will help you meet both goals.

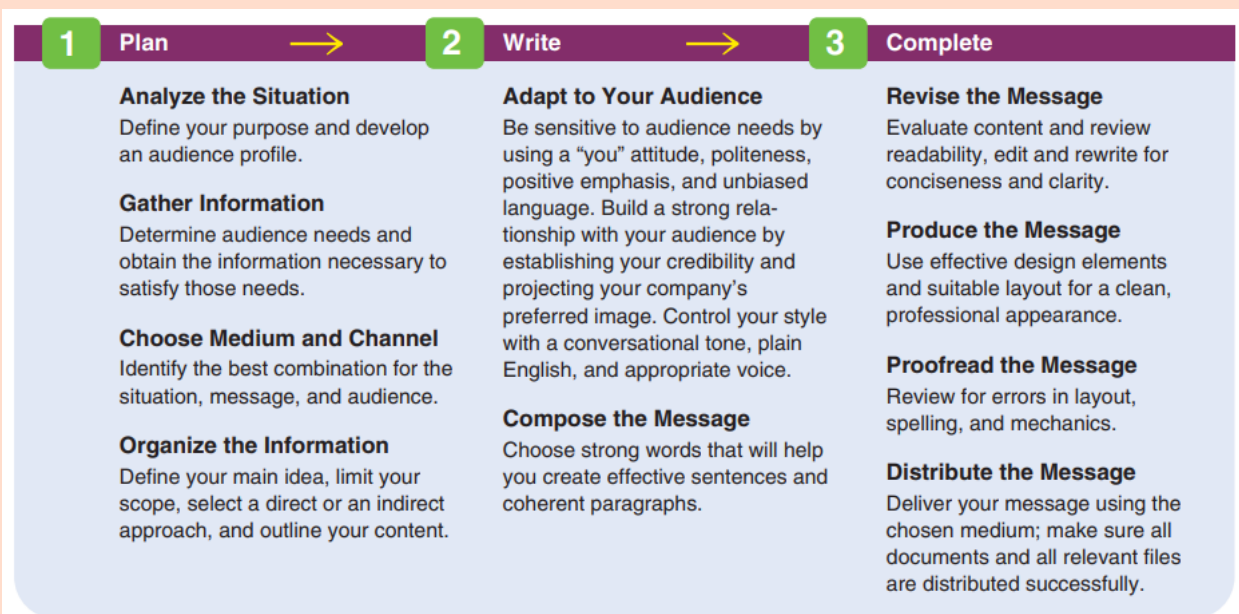


Figure 3.1 The Three-Step Writing Process

- ⊕ **Planning business messages.** To plan any message, first **analyze** the situation by defining your purpose and developing a profile of your audience. When you're sure about what you need to accomplish with your message, **gather the information** that will meet your audience's needs. Next, **select the right combination of media and channels** for producing and delivering your message. Then **organize the information** by defining your main idea, limiting your scope, selecting the direct or indirect approach, and outlining your content.
- ⊕ **Writing business messages.** After you've planned your message, **adapt your approach** to your audience with sensitivity, relationship skills, and style. Then you're ready to **compose your message** by choosing strong words, creating effective sentences, and developing coherent paragraphs.

- ⊕ **Completing business messages.** After writing your first draft, **revise** your message to make sure it is clear, concise, and correct. Next, **produce your message**, giving it an attractive, professional appearance. **Proofread** the final product to ensure high quality, and then **distribute your message**.

ANALYZING THE SITUATION

Every communication effort takes place in a particular situation, meaning that you have a specific message to share with a specific audience under a specific set of circumstances. Analyzing the situation gives you the insights necessary to meet your own needs as a communicator while also meeting the information needs of your recipients.

Situation

As the manager of a small marketing agency, you've noticed that employees have been missing project deadlines due to unclear instructions and communication gaps. To streamline workflow and improve collaboration, you've decided to implement **WorkFlow Pro**, a new project management software designed to help everyone stay organized and on schedule. This software is set to go live on November 15, and employees are required to install it on their work computers by November 10.

To ensure a smooth transition, you've scheduled a mandatory training session titled **WorkFlow Pro Basics** on November 12 at 2:00 PM in the main conference room. This session will be led by a software expert and will cover essential features and tips.

Some employees are known to feel hesitant about new technology, so you're aiming to make the transition as easy as possible. You'll be sending a business message to all employees, explaining why this change is necessary, how **WorkFlow Pro** will benefit their daily work, and encouraging them to attend the training session to learn the basics.

Defining Your Purpose

A successful message starts with a clear purpose that connects the sender's needs with the audience's needs.

All business messages have a **general purpose**: to inform, to persuade, to collaborate, or to initiate a conversation. This purpose helps define the overall approach you'll need to take. For example, in the situation above, the general purpose is to inform employees about the implementation of new project management software and encourage participation in a training session to improve workflow and project deadline adherence.

Within the scope of that general purpose, each message also has a **specific purpose**, which identifies what you hope to accomplish with your message. The more precisely you can define your specific purpose, the better you'll be able to fine-tune your message to achieve your desired outcome. For example, in the situation above, the specific purpose is to explain to employees the reasons for adopting *WorkFlow Pro* software, address potential concerns about using new technology, and motivate everyone to attend the *WorkFlow Pro Basics* training session on *November 12 at 2:00 PM*, and install the software by *November 10*, to ensure a smoother and more organized workflow in the agency.

After you have defined your specific purpose, make sure it merits the time and effort required for you to prepare and send the message. Ask the following four questions.

- ⊕ **Will anything change as a result of your message?** Make sure you don't contribute to information overload by sending messages that won't change anything. For instance, if you don't like your company's latest advertising campaign but you're not in a position to influence it, sending a critical message to your colleagues won't change anything and won't benefit anyone.
- ⊕ **Is your purpose realistic?** Recognizing whether a goal is realistic is an important part of having good business sense. For example, if you request a raise while the company is struggling, you might send the message that you're not tuned into the situation around you.
- ⊕ **Is the time right?** People who are busy or distracted when they receive your message are less likely to pay attention to it. Many professions and departments have recurring cycles in their workloads, for instance, and messages sent during peak times may be ignored.
- ⊕ **Is your purpose acceptable to your organization?** Your company's business objectives and policies, and even laws that apply to your industry, may dictate whether a given purpose is acceptable. For example, if you work for a discount stock brokerage, one that doesn't offer investing advice, it would be inappropriate to write a newsletter article on the pros and cons of investing in a particular company.

When you are satisfied that you have a clear and meaningful purpose and that now is a smart time to proceed, your next step is to understand the members of your audience and their needs.

Developing an Audience Profile

Before audience members will take the time to read or listen to your messages, they have to be interested in what you're saying. They need to know the message is relevant to their needs — even if they don't necessarily want to read or see it. The more you know about your audience members, their needs, and their expectations, the more effectively you'll be able to communicate with them. Conducting an audience analysis involves the following steps.

- ⊕ **Identify your primary audience.** For some messages, certain audience members might be more important than others. Don't ignore the needs of less influential members, but make sure you address the concerns of the key decision makers.
- ⊕ **Determine audience size and geographic distribution.** A message aimed at 10,000 people spread around the globe will likely require a different approach than one aimed at a dozen people down the hall.
- ⊕ **Determine audience composition.** Look for similarities and differences in culture, language, age, education, organizational rank and status, attitudes, experience, motivations, biases, beliefs, and any other factors that might affect the success of your message.
- ⊕ **Gauge audience members' level of understanding.** If audience members share your general background, they'll probably understand your material without difficulty. If not, your message may need an element of education to help people understand it.
- ⊕ **Understand audience expectations and preferences.** For example, will members of your audience expect complete details or just a summary of the main points?
- ⊕ **Forecast the audience's likely reaction.** The reaction you expect to get from your audience can help determine the best way to organize a message.

GATHERING INFORMATION

When you have a clear picture of your audience, your next step is to assemble the information you will include in your message. For simple messages, you may already have all the information at hand, but for more complex messages, you may need to do considerable research and analysis before you're ready to begin writing. Following are some of the sources you can gather information from.

Formal Sources: These include established, credible sources such as industry reports, research studies, and official publications. Formal sources are valuable for supporting your message with authoritative data or industry insights, which can help build credibility and trust with your audience. Use these sources to include statistical data, recent trends, or factual information that adds depth and reliability to your message.

Opinions of Others: Sometimes, it's useful to gather insights from different stakeholders. Their perspectives can provide a well-rounded view, especially if they have experience or knowledge that's relevant to the topic. Including others' opinions can also add balance to your message, helping you to anticipate potential questions or concerns from your audience and showing that you've considered multiple viewpoints.

Employees or Customers: Fellow workers and customers may have information you need, or they may have good insights into the needs of your target audience.

Interviews: Conducting interviews with key individuals can be a valuable way to collect specific, nuanced information, especially for complex messages. Interviews allow you to ask in-depth questions, clarify details, and gather firsthand insights that might not be available in written sources. They are particularly helpful when you need unique insights, real-life examples, or personal perspectives to enrich the message and make it more relatable to the audience.

Company Files: Annual reports, financial statements, news releases, blogs and microblogs by industry experts, marketing reports, and customer surveys are just a few of the many potential information sources. Find out whether your company has a **knowledge management system**, a database that collects the experiences and insights of employees throughout the organization.

Audience Input: If you're unsure what audience members need from your message, ask them, if possible. Admitting you don't know but want to meet their needs will impress an audience more than guessing and getting it wrong.

Providing Required Information

After you have defined your audience's information needs, your next step is to satisfy those needs completely. In addition to delivering the right quantity of information, you are responsible for verifying the quality of that information. Ask yourself these four questions.

- ⊕ **Is the information complete?** Completeness means providing all the information (**who, what, when, where, why, and how**) your audience needs to understand the message fully and make informed decisions or take appropriate action. This includes covering all essential details, explanations, and context required to prevent any confusion or misunderstandings. Make sure to include relevant background information, answer anticipated questions, and provide all necessary steps or next actions.
- ⊕ **Is the information accurate?** Inaccuracies can cause a host of problems, from embarrassment and lost productivity to serious safety and legal issues. Be sure to review any calculations and check all dates and schedules. Examine your own assumptions and conclusions to be sure they are valid.
- ⊕ **Is the information ethical?** By working hard to ensure the accuracy of the information you gather, you'll also avoid many ethical problems in your messages. However, messages can also be unethical if important information is omitted or obscured.
- ⊕ **Is the information pertinent?** Some points will be more important to your audience than others. By focusing on the information that concerns your audience the most, you increase your chances of sending an effective message.

SELECTING THE BEST COMBINATION OF MEDIA AND CHANNELS

With the necessary information in hand, your next decision involves the best combination of media and channels to reach your target audience. Most media can be distributed through more than one channel, so whenever you have a choice, think through your options to select the optimum combination. For example, a brief written message could be distributed as a printed letter or memo, or it could be distributed through a variety of digital channels, from workgroup messaging to blogging to social networking.

The Most Common Media and Channel Options

Oral Channel	Written Channel
⊕ Face-to-Face	⊕ Memos
⊕ Telephone	⊕ Letters
⊕ Meetings	⊕ Reports
⊕ Voice Mail	⊕ E-mail
⊕ Videotape	⊕ Websites
⊕ Teleconferencing	⊕ Instant Messages

Factors to Consider When Choosing Media and Channels

When choosing media and channels for business communication, several factors must be considered to ensure effective delivery and reception of the message.

1. Style and Tone (Formal/Informal): The style and tone of the message should align with the audience and context. Formal communications are suitable for professional settings, while informal tones may be better for casual interactions.

Example: A company announcing a new policy to employees might use a formal tone in a memo, stating, "We are implementing a new work-from-home policy effective immediately." Conversely, a casual email to the team about a potluck could say, "Hey everyone! Let's have some fun and bring your favorite dish!"

2. Feedback: The chosen medium should facilitate feedback. Some channels allow for immediate responses, while others may not.

Example: A video conference allows real-time interaction and immediate feedback from participants, whereas a newsletter may only provide one-way communication, making it difficult for the audience to ask questions or provide input.

3. Audience Perception: Understanding how the audience perceives different media is crucial. Some audiences may favor certain channels over others based on their preferences or experiences.

Example: Younger audiences may prefer social media updates (like Instagram or Twitter) for announcements, while older professionals might favor traditional emails or printed newsletters for more formal communications.

4. Time (Urgent?): The urgency of the message can influence the choice of medium. Immediate concerns may require faster communication methods.

Example: If there's a last-minute change in meeting time, sending a quick text message or using a messaging app like WhatsApp may be more effective than sending an email, which may not be checked immediately.

5. Cost: Budget constraints can affect the choice of media. Some channels may incur costs, while others may be free or less expensive.

Example: Hosting a webinar may require investment in a platform like Zoom or Webex, whereas sending a simple email update incurs no additional cost. For a non-profit organization, using social media for outreach may be preferred due to its low cost compared to print advertising.

6. Audience Expectation: Audience expectations regarding communication style and frequency should be taken into account. Different audiences may expect different types of engagement.

Example: Customers may expect quick responses on social media (e.g., Twitter or Facebook), whereas employees may anticipate a weekly team meeting for updates. Failing to meet these expectations could lead to dissatisfaction or disengagement.

RELATING TO THE AUDIENCE

Relating to the audience requires the communicator to include the following factors in their message.



The “You” Attitude

Instead of This	Use This
To help us process this order, we must ask for another copy of the requisition.	So that your order can be filled promptly, please send another copy of the requisition.
You should never use that type of paper in the copy machine.	That type of paper doesn’t work very well in the copy machine.
We need you to submit your report by Friday.	Please submit your report by Friday to help us stay on schedule.
It is our policy to limit returns to 30 days.	For your convenience, returns can be made within 30 days.
Our team will respond to your inquiry within 24 hours.	You can expect a response to your inquiry within 24 hours.
You have failed to meet the deadline.	The deadline has passed, and we look forward to your future submissions.
You should consider joining our loyalty program.	Joining our loyalty program can offer you valuable rewards.

Emphasize the Positive

Instead of This	Use This
It is impossible to repair your vacuum cleaner today.	Your vacuum cleaner will be ready by Tuesday.
We cannot deliver your order until next week.	Your order will be delivered next week.
This product is out of stock.	This product will be back in stock soon.
Unfortunately, we can't accommodate your request.	We appreciate your request and will do our best to assist you.
Your subscription has expired.	Renewing your subscription will give you continued access to our services.
This task will take longer than expected.	We’re working hard to complete this task as quickly as possible.
We are unable to meet your deadline.	We will do our best to meet your timeline moving forward.
⊕ Cheap merchandise ⊕ Toilet paper ⊕ Elderly person	⊕ Bargain prices ⊕ Bathroom tissue ⊕ Senior citizen

Be Polite

Instead of This	Use This
You really fouled things up with that last computer run.	Let's review what went wrong so that the next computer run goes smoothly.
You've been sitting on our order for two weeks. We need it now!	We are eager to receive our order. When can we expect delivery?
Your report is late.	I wanted to check in on the status of your report.
You forgot to attach the document.	Could you please resend the document when you have a moment?
You need to pay your bill immediately.	We kindly remind you that your bill is due soon.
You made a mistake in your calculations.	There seems to be an error in your calculations; let's take a look at it together.
Your work is not up to standard.	I believe we can enhance your work with some additional guidance.
You are not allowed to enter this area.	For safety reasons, access to this area is restricted.
You didn't respond to our last email.	I wanted to follow up on my previous email to see if you had a chance to review it.
You need to adjust your approach.	I recommend considering a different approach that might yield better results.

Use Bias-Free Language

Examples	Unacceptable	Preferable
Gender Bias		
Using Words Containing <i>Man</i>	Man-made	Artificial, synthetic, manufactured, constructed, human-made
	Mankind	Humanity, human beings, human race, people
	Manpower	Workers, workforce
	Businessman	Executive, manager, businessperson, professional
	Salesman	Sales representative, salesperson
	Foreman	Supervisor
Using Female-Gender Words	Actress Stewardess	Actor Flight Attendant

Examples	Unacceptable	Preferable
Gender Bias (contd.)		
Using Special Designations	Woman doctor Male Nurse	Doctor Nurse
Using <i>He</i> to Refer to "Everyone"	The average worker ... he	The average worker ... he or she OR Average workers ... they
Identifying Roles with Gender	The typical executive spends four hours of his day in meetings. The consumer ... she The nurse/teacher ... she	Most executives spend four hours a day in meetings. Consumers ... they Nurses/teachers ... they
Identifying Women by Marital Status	Mrs. Afzal Haque Afzal Haque and Mrs. Chowdhury	Sumona Haque OR Ms. Sumona Haque Afzal Haque and Sumona Chowdhury OR Mr. Haque and Ms. Chowdhury
Racial and Ethnic Bias		
Assigning Stereotypes	Not surprisingly, Shing-Tung Yau excels in mathematics.	Shing-Tung Yau excels in mathematics.
Identifying People by Race or Ethnicity	Alex Dev Chowdhury, Indian-American politician and ex-governor of New York	Alex Dev Chowdhury, politician and ex-governor of New York
Age Bias		
Including Age When Irrelevant	Afsana Haque, 62, has just joined our trust department.	Afsana Haque has just joined our trust department.
Disability Bias		
Putting the Disability Before the Person	Disabled workers face many barriers on the job. An epileptic, Rina has no trouble doing her job.	Workers with physical disabilities face many barriers on the job. Rina's epilepsy has no effect on her job performance.

Establish Credibility

Establishing credibility is crucial in communication, especially in professional settings. Following are some ways you can establish credibility.

1. Show Your Understanding: Demonstrating knowledge of the topic or the audience's needs helps build trust. This can be done by addressing specific concerns, providing relevant examples, or referencing industry trends. When your audience sees that you understand their situation, they are more likely to listen and engage.

2. Explain Your Credentials: Sharing your qualifications, experience, and expertise related to the topic at hand establishes your authority. This might include mentioning relevant education, certifications, or previous work experiences that relate to the subject. It assures the audience that you have the necessary background to speak on the matter.

3. Avoid Exaggerating: Staying honest and realistic about your capabilities and outcomes is vital for maintaining credibility. Exaggerations can lead to skepticism and damage your reputation if the audience feels misled. It's better to be straightforward about what you can offer or what results can be expected.

4. Believe in Yourself: Confidence plays a significant role in how your message is received. When you believe in yourself and your expertise, it positively influences your delivery and engages your audience. This self-assurance can inspire trust and encourage others to value your perspective.

Project the Company's Image

Projecting the company's image is essential for maintaining a positive reputation and fostering trust. Following are some ways you can do it.

1. Be a Spokesperson: Representing the company involves embodying its values, mission, and culture in your communications. As a spokesperson, it's important to deliver messages that reflect the organization's goals and principles, whether in meetings, presentations, or public engagements. Your words and actions should align with the company's identity to foster a consistent image.

2. Convey the Right Impression: The way you present yourself—through your tone, language, and demeanor—can significantly influence how the company is perceived. Strive to be professional, approachable, and knowledgeable. This helps create a positive impression and reinforces the company's reputation as reliable and competent.

3. Minimize Your Own Views: When representing the company, it's crucial to prioritize its perspective over personal opinions. This means focusing on the company's message and values, rather than injecting personal biases or viewpoints. This approach helps maintain a unified voice and strengthens the company's image as cohesive and professional.

4. Maximize Company Interests: Always consider how your actions and communications can benefit the company. This includes highlighting its achievements, addressing concerns that reflect its values, and promoting initiatives that align with its objectives. By prioritizing company interests, you enhance its image and contribute to its success.

REVIEW AND DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

A. Theoretical/Conceptual Questions

1. "Effective business messages are purposeful, audience-centered, and concise, ensuring clear and impactful communication." - explain.
2. Explain the three-step writing process.
3. What are a general purpose and a specific purpose? Explain with examples.
4. Conducting an audience analysis involves what steps? Explain.
5. What are the sources from where you can gather information?
6. What questions you should ask yourself while providing required information?
7. What are some of the most common media and channel options?
8. What factors should one consider while choosing media and channels?

B. Situational/Contextual Questions

1. A day after sending an email to all 1,800 employees in your company regarding income tax implications of the company's retirement plan, you discover that one of the sources you relied on for your information plagiarized from other sources. You quickly double-check all the information in your message and confirm that it is accurate. However, you are concerned about using plagiarized information, even though you did nothing wrong. How you would handle this situation?
2. You are organizing an exploratory in-person meeting with engineering representatives from a dozen manufacturers around the world to discuss updates to a technical standard that all the companies' products must adhere to. The representatives have a wide range of firmly held opinions on the subject, because the changes could help some companies and hurt others. They can't even agree on what should be addressed in the first meeting, so you need to develop a minimum level of consensus on what should be on the agenda. Which combination of media and channels would you use to move the conversation forward and finalize the agenda? Each company has one representative, and any discussions need to be kept confidential.

C. Practice Your Skills

Rewrite the following sentences to reflect your audience's viewpoint.

1. We request that you include the order number with your inquiry.
2. We insist that you always bring your credit card to the store.
3. I can't get my reports in on time if you won't finalize the sales data.
4. As a measure of our goodwill, we are sending the refund for \$25.

Revise these sentences to be positive rather than negative.

5. To avoid damage to your credit rating, please remit payment within 10 days.
6. We don't give refunds for returned merchandise that is soiled.
7. You should have realized that waterbeds will freeze in unheated houses during winter. Therefore, our guarantee does not cover the valve damage and you must pay the \$9.50 valve-replacement fee (plus postage).

Revise the following sentences to replace unflattering terms (in italics) with euphemisms.

8. The new boss is _____ (*stubborn*) when it comes to doing things by the book.
9. When you say we've doubled our profit level, you are _____ (*wrong*).
10. Just be careful not to make any _____ (*stupid*) choices this week.
11. Jim Riley is _____ (*incompetent*) for that kind of promotion.

Revise the following sentences to make them more courteous.

12. You claim that you mailed your check last Thursday, but we have not received it.

13. It is not our policy to exchange sale items, especially after they have been worn.
14. You neglected to sign the enclosed contract.
15. You failed to enclose your instructions for your new will.

Rewrite each of the following sentences to eliminate bias.

16. A pilot must have the ability to stay calm under pressure, and then he must be trained to cope with any problem that arises.
17. Candidate Renata Parsons, married and the mother of a teenager, will attend the debate.
18. For as old as he is, Sam Nugent is still one of our most active sales reps.